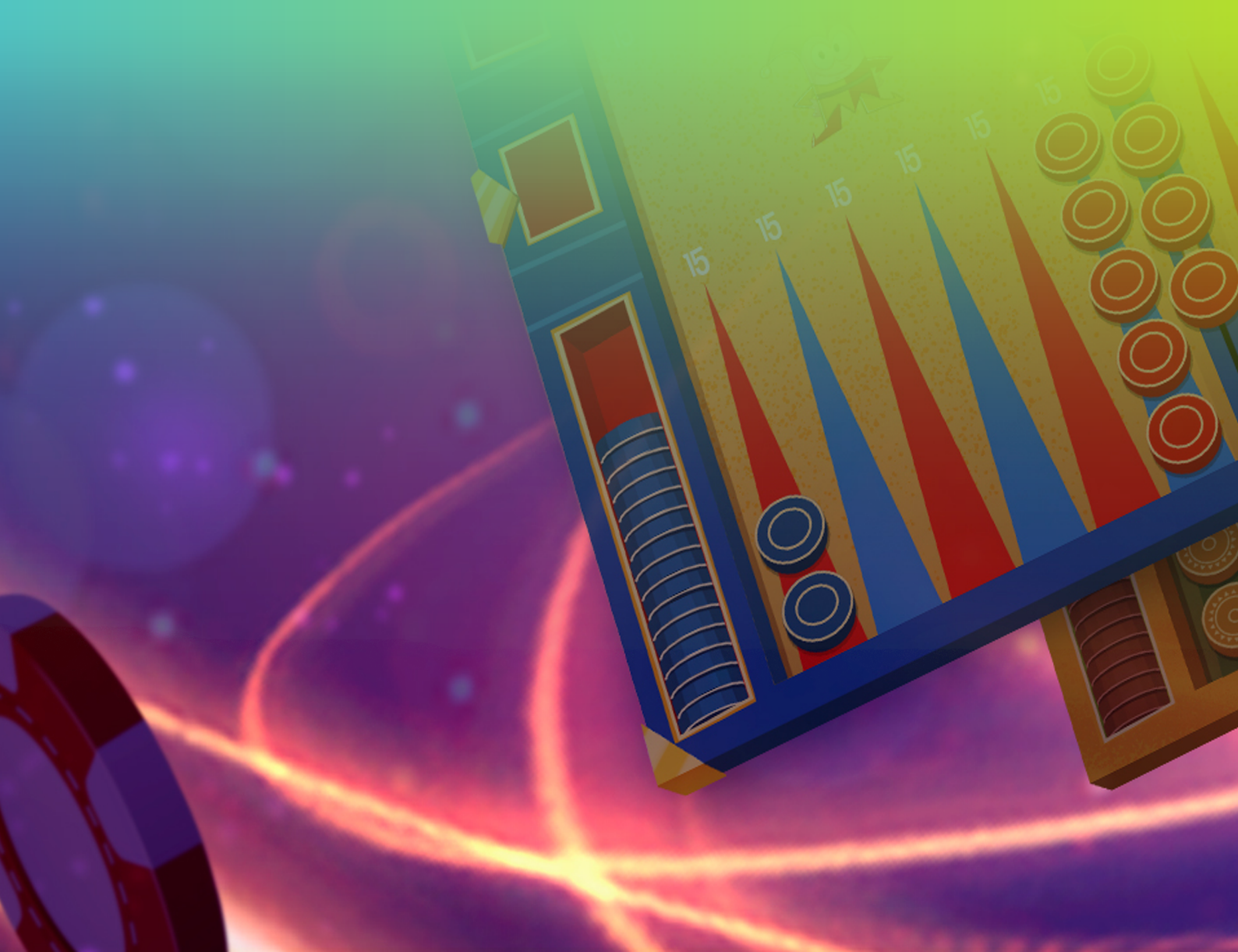


IG0741 – Indie Game Startup

Acey Deucey

BUSINESS PLAN



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Business Plan

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MODULE

IG0741 — Indie Game Startup

SEMESTER

Autumn

YEAR

2025





Company Overview



To reinvent traditional game genres through contemporary video-game design.

Stones & Dice is a UK-based indie game studio located just outside London in the south-east of England. The studio is currently led by a single developer, *David Reay*, supported by a small network of freelance artists who contribute to production as required.

Game Concept

Title: Acey Deucey

Platform: PC (Steam)

Genre: Deck-building, Roguelite, Tables

Rating: 18+

Genre

Acey Deucey is conceptualised as a modern *roguelite* reimagining of the tables-based games genre; the most prominent Western example of this genre is **Backgammon** (Wikipedia, 2025a, 2025b).

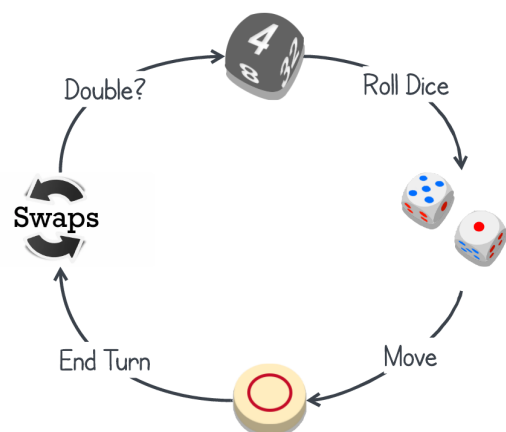
With the advent of computers, digital versions of Backgammon have multiplied, yet there has been little *mechanical* innovation since the introduction of the doubling cube in the 1920's, despite the long history of the game and its many regional variants (Backgammon Galore!, 2025a; Canada Backgammon Association (CBGA), 2025).

In the same way that **Balatro** reimagined Big Two through modern video-game design and applying the score based achievement from *Luck be a Landlord* (Wilde, 2024), *Acey Deucey* aims to introduce run based meta-progression and deck-building to the existing Backgammon game-loop, to build a distinctive, original title.

Mechanics

Core Gameplay Loop

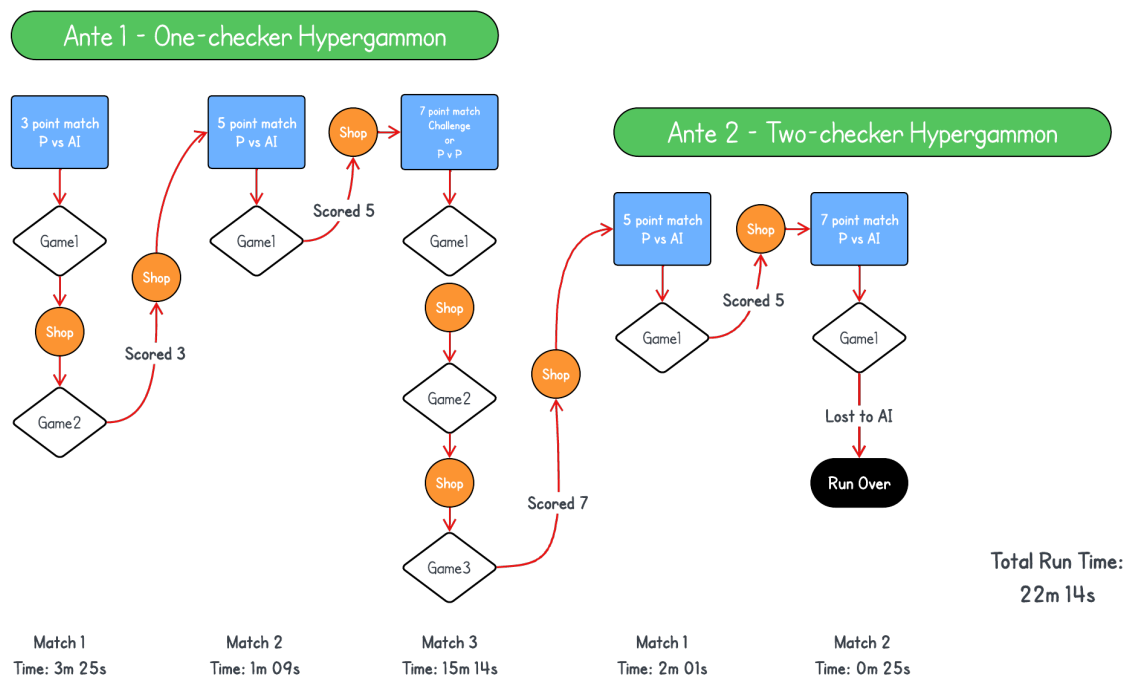
Play alternates after a shared opening roll, with dice driving randomness and the doubling cube—uncapped in *Acey Deucey*—raising the stakes. The addictive core loop delivers strong moment-to-moment engagement, which then extends to minute-to-minute across the games of a pointed threshold match. **Short-term fun** is reinforced through responsive animations, clear dice and movement feedback, satisfying audio cues, and impactful modifier effects that keep each action readable and rewarding even as complexity increases (Lobb, 2015).



Run Based Meta-progression

To appeal to longer levels of engagement, the core structure extends across a run consisting of 9 ante's, each comprising three matches; a format inspired by both *Balatro* and traditional tables

games such as *Tavli* (Backgammon Galore!, 2025b). The final match of each ante culminates in an **online PvP battle**, drawing on the successful community implementation seen in the Balatro multiplayer mod (Balatro Multiplayer Mod Team, 2025).



A match may be won in one game or extend across several. Match rewards fund deck-building, while skipping shops risks being underpowered later, creating a trade-off between run velocity and survival. *Match/ante progression sustain minute/hour-scale engagement*¹ (Lobb, 2015).

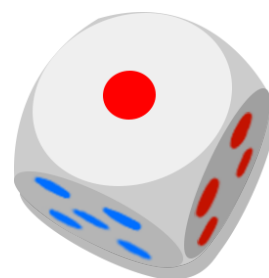
Deck Building

Magic Eight Ball



Increased chance of rolling an effective "8" (2/6, 3/5, 4/4).

Chinese Dice



Grants a fortune cookie when a red roll occurs (1 or 4).

Examples of shop items available during a run. These modifiers shape gameplay in distinct ways and support a variety of deck-building strategies, each with its own trade-offs.

¹For further details on day-to-day and long-term engagement strategies, see the Game Design Document and the Gamification chapter.

Marketability hooks

Acey Deucey's marketability is driven by a combination of pre and post-play hooks: striking visuals that capture attention instantly, and streamer-friendly systems designed to generate viral, shareable moments.

Pre-play Hooks



This casino-themed board uses green felt, white point markings, playing cards, and money motifs to signal a **mature, gambling-inspired** aesthetic. These tropes align with the target audience and echo the visual appeal seen in titles like *Balatro*, helping the game stand out in screenshots and other pre-play marketing materials.

Post-play Hooks

PvP



Streaming-friendly multiplayer mode, enabling competitive battles that naturally generate spectator interest.

Break the Game



Players push beyond intended limits—such as exceeding the ante cap or achieving absurdly high scores.

Push the Button



Players configure a deck of modifiers, then trigger a "Rollout" that resolves the game automatically.

Post-play hooks draw on proven community-driven streaming formats such as *Major League Balatro* (Major League Balatro Community, 2025), where competitive play has evolved into a popular Twitch and YouTube spectacle. Roguelike mechanics such as intentional "game breaking" and auto-battling provide further streamer-friendly appeal.

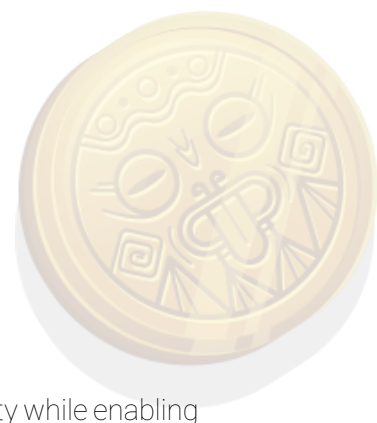
Financial Planning

Budget

Revised 18-month lean development budget: Solo Unity Developer with freelance 2D art support.

Category	Description	Cost (\$)	Notes
— Staffing Costs (18 Months) —			
Unity Developer (Founder)	Core gameplay, systems, UI, and implementation.	75,000	1.5-year "living wage" draw (\$50k/yr).
— Production Expenses (Outsourced & Misc) —			
Freelance 2D Art & UI	Boards, 150+ card illustrations, icons, and UI skinning.	40,000	Contracted high-impact aesthetic assets.
Software & Licenses	Unity Pro, Adobe CC, and productivity tools.	2,500	18-month subscription period.
Unity Asset Packs	VFX, SFX, and "juice" utility scripts (Feel, etc.).	1,500	One-time commercial licences.
Marketing & PR	Professional trailer, Steam capsule art, and outreach.	7,500	Increased to boost market "resonance."
Hardware & Legal	Development hardware, trademarks, and IP filing.	4,000	Essential solo-studio setup costs.
Contingency (13%)	Buffer for production delays or additional assets.	17,500	Provides flexibility for the 1.5-year cycle.
Total Staffing		75,000	Founder/Lead Developer salary.
Total Production		73,000	Outsourcing and operational costs.
Grand Total		148,000	Total 18-month project budget.





Funding

This project adopts a staged, risk-aware model designed to protect financial stability while enabling the game to progress toward commercial viability, built on three core principles:

- **Validate before committing:** Early development focuses on confirming that the concept resonates with players through wishlists, playtests, and retention metrics (Della Rocca, 2017).
- **Scale investment only after traction:** If strong signals of demand emerge, external funding sources will be pursued to support full-time development (Atlas & Short, 2018).
- **Pivot if market fit is weak:** If early testing indicates limited commercial potential, the project will be redirected toward a smaller, more focused concept instead of continuing with an unviable scope (Birkett, 2016).

The strategy is intentionally conservative, prioritising validation before investment and pivoting when market signals are weak. This ensures financial resilience while preparing the project for publisher, grant, or angel funding, and supports a sustainable long-tail revenue model consistent with indie industry research (Birkett, 2016).

#	Milestone	Description
1	Prototype (completed)	Confirms feasibility of the core mechanic.
2	Vertical slice	Establishes audiovisual quality and representative gameplay.
3	First playable	Introduces procedural systems, early boards, and modifiers.
4	Steam playtest & wishlist validation	Primary market test for demand.
5	Content complete	Full feature set, assets, and polished UI.
6	Beta & launch funding	Final polish, marketing, and platform submission.
7	Launch	Supported by a structured post-launch roadmap.

To minimise financial risk, the project follows a checkpoint-driven funding model. External funding will only be pursued once the playtest phase provides credible evidence of audience demand.

Preferred funding routes include **publisher partnerships**, **grants** such as the UK Games Fund or Innovate UK, and ongoing **self-funding through consulting income**. Post-launch revenue will be driven by periodic content updates, optional cosmetic DLC and variant rulesets, bundle participation, platform promotions, and eventual console and mobile ports once PC performance is validated.

Revenue Projections

Comparable Sales and Revenue Benchmarks for Indie roguelike deckbuilders priced between \$10–\$25 show a wide revenue range. The data points below show that well-received games in this niche can realistically reach six-figure unit sales. Failure to gain traction, however, often results in sales of under 50,000 copies, suggesting a strong dependence on visibility, influencers, and Steam algorithm performance.

Game	Year	Price	Units Sold	Est. Revenue	Sources
Slay the Spire	2017	\$15–\$20	3M (Steam); 8M total	\$45M–\$160M	(GameDeveloper.com, 2025; LEVVVEL.com, 2025)
Balatro	2024	\$14.99	5M+	\$75M+	(GamingBolt, 2024; PC Gamer, 2024)
Monster Train	2020	\$25	1.5M+	\$37.5M+	(TheXboxHub, 2024)
Luck Be a Landlord	2021	\$9.99	700k–800k	\$7.0M–\$8.0M	(Gamalytic, 2025c)
Dicey Dungeons	2019	\$14.99	~800k	\$6M–\$12M	(Gamalytic, 2025a)

Comparable sales and estimated revenues for leading roguelite and deck-building titles.

Forecast scenarios based on current genre benchmarks outline three potential revenue paths. Each model assumes a \$14.99 Steam price point and reflects net earnings after the standard 30% platform fee.

Scenario	Units Sold	Gross Revenue (\$)	Net Revenue (\$)
Conservative	25,000	374,750	262,325
Realistic	100,000	1,499,000	1,049,300
Optimistic	500,000	7,495,000	5,246,500

Estimated revenue scenarios based on Steam benchmarks.

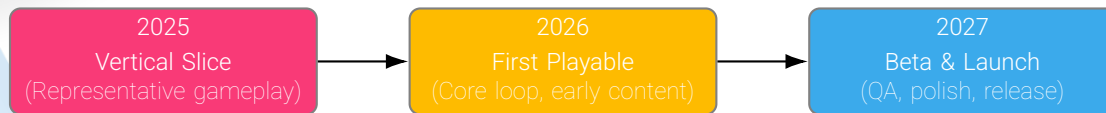
Revenue potential is influenced by several key factors, including **wishlist conversion**, which typically ranges from 10–20% (Game If You Are, 2024); **visibility boosts** such as Steam featuring, influencer coverage, or viral appeal driven by distinctive mechanics or art direction; **DLC and live-ops opportunities** through post-launch updates, new boards, seasonal events, and cosmetic add-ons; and **localisation and platform expansion**, with future releases on mobile or console offering the potential to significantly broaden audience reach.

Positioned as a medium-scope Steam release with strong replayability, *Acey Deucey* is looking to target a minimum of 25k units sold (approximately \$260k net) at launch, while prioritising community momentum and store visibility. If early signals are positive—such as reaching 10k wishlists or generating notable streamer interest—the roadmap can accelerate toward wider platform support.



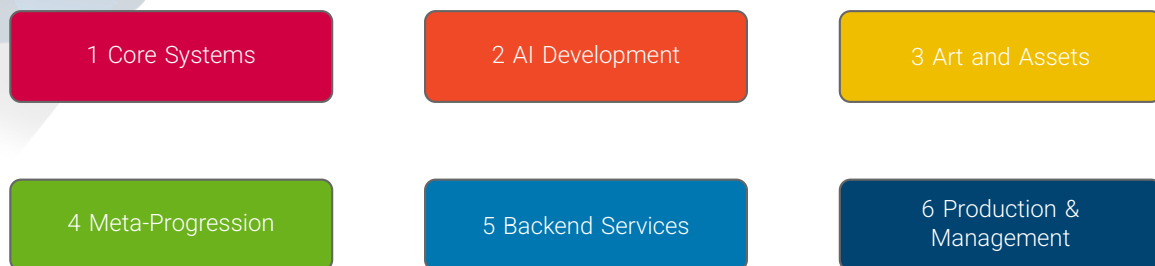
Production Plan

The development approach follows established project-management practices tailored to the constraints of indie production. It is structured around a Work Breakdown Structure (WBS), milestone-driven scheduling, and phased development that prioritises validation, risk mitigation, and scope control (Ask Gamedev, 2019; Birkett, 2016; Clayton, 2019a, 2019b).



High-level development roadmap for *Acey Deucey*. A detailed Gantt chart is provided in Appendix ??.

Using Work Breakdown Structure (WBS) the project is organised into six major workstreams to ensure clarity, reduce hidden workload, and provide a stable basis for estimation (Clayton, 2019b). A



Six major workstreams: *core systems* (dice, board rules, modifiers); *AI development* (evaluation engine, training pipelines, behaviours); *art and assets* (2D themes, UI/UX, 3D boards and pieces); *meta-progression* (runs, antes, shop systems); *backend services* (accounts, cloud saves, analytics); and *production* (QA, builds, documentation).

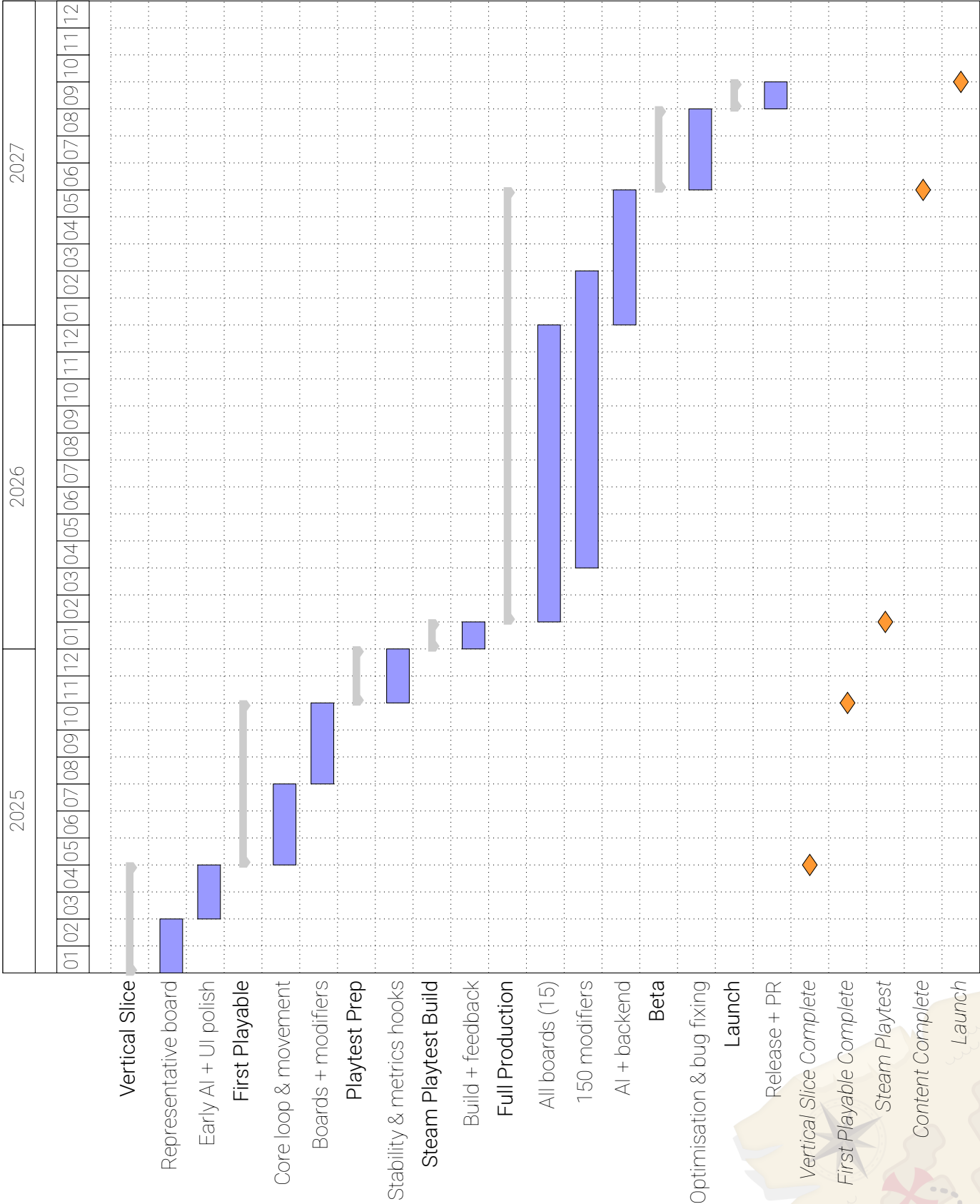
vertical slice is produced early to validate production quality, refine scope, and identify bottlenecks. Scope control follows Jonas Tyroller's prioritisation principles (Tyroller, 2020) and an MVP-first approach, ensuring that additional features are added only when the core experience is validated. Key

Phase	Duration	Key Outputs
Pre-Production	Completed	Prototype, ruleset research, initial modifiers, art tests.
Vertical Slice	3–4 months	Full-quality single board, early AI, polished UI, representative gameplay.
First Playable	4–6 months	Core loop, multiple boards, modifiers, early progression systems.
Steam Playtest Build	1 month	Wishlist validation, retention metrics, community feedback.
Full Production	12–18 months	All 15 boards, 150 modifiers, 3D environments, final AI, backend integration.
Beta	3–4 months	Optimisation, polish, bug-fixing, marketing asset creation.
Launch	1 month	Steam release, PR activities, influencer outreach.

Milestones and development phases following Ask Gamedev (Ask Gamedev, 2019) and Della Rocca's checkpoint model (Della Rocca, 2017).

risks include underestimated art workloads, AI complexity, scope expansion, and personal capacity constraints. These are managed through milestone-based decision points, and a dedicated **10% budget contingency** (Birkett, 2016). Combined, these measures create a structured and adaptable production framework, enabling the project to scale responsibly, pivot when necessary, and maintain progress in line with validated market interest.

Gantt Chart



Marketing Plan

Target Audience

Roguelite deck-building hybrids mainly attract adult male players aged 18–34, with continued engagement into 35–44 (Verified Market Reports, 2024). While men still dominate roguelike and card-strategy genres, female participation is increasing, with around 25% of roguelike players identifying as female (Wikipedia contributors, 2025). This audience values strategic depth, replayability, procedural variety, and decision-making that rewards synergy and long-term optimisation (Reddit Users, 2024b). Mature players also respond well to darker or experimental themes, as seen in *In-scription*, *Balatro*, and *Luck be a Landlord*. Active online communities amplify discovery through theorycrafting and word-of-mouth (Verified Market Reports, 2024), positioning any title with strong mechanics and a distinctive thematic identity to gain traction.”

Age: 29

Gender: Male

Occupation: Software engineer (fintech)

Location: Manchester, UK

Budget: Moderate–high disposable income

Background & Lifestyle. Alex works in a technical role, enjoys logic-driven hobbies, and uses gaming as both relaxation and a competitive outlet. He follows Steam recommendations, YouTube analysis, and Reddit discussions to discover new titles.

Gaming Habits. Plays 1–2 hours on weeknights; prefers PC; alternates between roguelites, deck-builders, and strategy titles; experiments with synergies; reads theorycrafting threads.

Motivations. Seeks strategic mastery, meaningful randomness, replayability, long-term meta-progression, and systems that reward insight.

Thematic Preferences. Comfortable with darker or experimental themes; enjoys mystery, moral ambiguity, humour, satire, and casino-inspired motifs.

Community Engagement. Reads forums regularly, values transparent developer communication, shares strong builds occasionally, and relies on community consensus before purchasing.

Pain Points. Avoids shallow randomness, weak progression, low challenge, or slow, tutorial-heavy openings.

Appeal Factors. Responds to mechanical depth, distinctive themes, rewarding decision-making, and systems that generate shareable strategies.

Likelihood to Recommend. If a game provides layered systems, clever synergies, and a fresh thematic identity, Alex becomes a strong advocate within theorycrafting and strategy-focused communities.



Alex Grant

Strategy-Driven Roguelite Enthusiast



Trends

Art Direction

Stylised 2D art dominates, ranging from the dark, hand-drawn aesthetic of *Slay the Spire* to the bright, quirky cartoon style of *Dicey Dungeons* (Valve Corporation, 2019). Pixel art also remains a major pillar, with *Balatro* using retro visuals to reinforce its casino-inspired identity (Valve Corporation, 2024). UI clarity is critical: cards, dice, icons, and modifiers must be readable at a glance. Most titles employ bold iconography, strong colour coding, and lightweight animations to maintain responsiveness in fast run-based loops.

Themes

Fantasy adventure remains the most common framing, including dungeon-crawling (*Slay the Spire*) and infernal rail-running in *Monster Train* (Valve Corporation, 2020b). Alongside this, casino and gambling motifs have surged—poker-like logic in *Balatro*, slot-machine rhythms in *Luck be a Landlord*, and emerging dice-gambling roguelites highlighted in contemporary coverage (Gamer, 2024). Horror and occult themes continue to perform well, with *Inscription* demonstrating strong appetite for psychological tension (SteamSpy, 2024), while lighter game-show or parody tones, as in *Dicey Dungeons*, broaden mainstream appeal (Valve Corporation, 2019). A distinctive thematic hook remains essential for visibility in a crowded market.

Gameplay Loops

Genre-defining loops centre on 30–120 minute runs, escalating challenges, and frequent failure followed by rapid retries. Common structures include: **Build Customisation**. Players expect run-to-run variation through drafted rewards, shops, and events that reshape builds, as seen in *Slay the Spire* and *Monster Train*. **Procedural Generation**. Randomised encounters, loot, and maps drive replayability; fans expect controlled randomness—unpredictable enough to force adaptation, but not arbitrary. **Meta-Progression**. Persistent unlocks (cards, relics, classes) create long-term goals and are now standard across the genre. **Difficulty & Accessibility**. Popular titles offer scalable challenge—e.g., Ascension modes—alongside clear tooltips and optional easing features to support onboarding without reducing depth. **Hybridisation**. Modern titles increasingly combine deckbuilding with secondary systems: RPG dialogue in *Griftlands*, tactical grid combat in *Trials of Fire*, or party mechanics in *Chrono Ark*. Blending backgammon's positional strategy and dice-based risk assessment with deckbuilding aligns directly with this movement toward hybrid design.

Production & Post-Launch Trends

Successful entries benefit from strong post-launch support: balance updates, new cards or relics, and occasional DLC. Modding tools, when feasible, increase longevity and community engagement. Players are also familiar with genre-wide UX conventions—card frames, relic bars, node-based maps—so new titles succeed when they honour these expectations while introducing fresh mechanical or thematic twists.

Competitors

Slay the Spire — MegaCrit, 2019

The genre's breakout hit, *Slay the Spire* surpassed 1.5 million sales by early 2019 (GamesBeat, 2019) and exceeded three million shortly after. Priced at \$24.99 (often discounted), it holds a 97% approval rating from 180k+ Steam reviews (SteamDB, 2025b). Its four distinct characters, 300+ cards, and adaptive decision-making established the benchmark for strategic single-player deck-builders (Reddit Users, 2024a).

Balatro — LocalThunk / Playstack, 2024

A poker-inspired roguelite, *Balatro* sold 3.5 million copies within ten months of release (Game World Observer, 2024b) and passed five million by 2025. Launched at \$14.99, it maintains a 96–98% rating from 170k+ reviews (SteamDB, 2025a). Players praise its extreme combo potential, high-risk casino theming, and pixel-art aesthetic (Valve Corporation, 2024). The developer explicitly cited *Luck be a Landlord* as an influence (Valve Corporation, 2020a), reinforcing the rise of gambling-motif roguelites.

Monster Train — Shiny Shoe, 2020

Monster Train introduced multi-lane, tower-defense-style combat (Valve Corporation, 2020b). Priced at \$24.99 (heavily discounted during promotions Boiling Steam, 2020), it achieved an estimated 1.5 million sales (Facebook, 2024) and maintains a 96% positive rating from 12,000 reviews. Five combinable clans support high synergy diversity, and an optional real-time multiplayer mode adds competitive depth.

Inscription — Daniel Mullins / Devolver Digital, 2021

Blending card-based roguelite play with puzzles and psychological horror (SteamSpy, 2024), *Inscription* sold one million copies within three months (PCGamesN, 2021) and reached 1.46 million within a year (Game World Observer, 2024a). Priced at \$19.99, it remains at 97% positive reviews. Its genre-bending structure, eerie tabletop aesthetic, and shifting mechanics show that narrative-driven experimentation can expand the deckbuilder audience far beyond traditional fans.

Luck be a Landlord — TrampolineTales, 2021–2023

A slot-machine-based roguelite, *Luck be a Landlord* sold primarily through strong word-of-mouth. Priced at \$9.99, it has 9,800+ reviews at 93% positive (Valve Corporation, 2020a). Its humour, satirical framing, and synergy-stacking systems helped inspire later gambling-themed hybrids—including *Balatro* (Valve Corporation, 2020a).

Dicey Dungeons — Terry Cavanagh, 2019

Dicey Dungeons combines dice-rolling with roguelite progression, selling an estimated 0.8 million units (Gamalytic, 2025b). At \$14.99, it holds a 90% rating across 6,000 reviews (Valve Corporation, 2019). Its six classes and cheerful game-show presentation demonstrate that light-hearted themes and board-game mechanics can succeed within a strategy-focused genre.

Differentiation Strategies

Fresh Core Mechanic

Backgammon's movement rules and tactical interactions translate cleanly into cards, abilities, and board modifications. Cards might alter movement, introduce special dice, or mutate board layouts mid-run. This creates a strategic identity distinct from conventional card-battlers while appealing to players familiar with board-game logic.

Blend of Strategy and Chance

Backgammon's balance of luck and skill aligns naturally with roguelite design. Dice-driven opportunity paired with positional strategy mirrors the "push-your-luck" dynamics valued by deckbuilder communities (Reddit Users, 2024b). Cards could modify probability distributions or influence board states, satisfying both gambling-oriented players (e.g., fans of *Balatro* and *Luck be a Landlord*) and strategy-focused audiences.

Thematic Resonance

The backgammon board can be reimagined as a battlefield, cosmic arena, noir casino, or underground tournament. Mature 18+ themes—war, crime, occult, or high-stakes gambling—fit the demographic. The doubling cube naturally supports escalating risk–reward decisions, reinforcing the tension central to roguelite progression.

Strategic Depth & Replayability

Backgammon's layers—pip counting, timing, containment, hit-and-run tactics—offer extensive design space. Procedural boards, rule variants, traps, shifting home boards, alternate dice sets, and asymmetric layouts can provide run-level variety. Unlockable abilities (re-rolls, fortifications, forced hits, probabilistic buffs) echo the synergistic build-crafting that drives replayability in modern deck-builders.

Untapped Board-Game Hybrid Niche

Few titles merge classic board games with roguelite deck-building. The success of hybrids like *Peglin* (pachinko-roguelite) and *Balatro* (poker-roguelite) shows strong appetite for familiar analog mechanics reimagined through modern roguelite design. A backgammon hybrid could pioneer this niche, offering a clear pitch—"Slay the Spire meets Backgammon"—well suited to press and influencer coverage.



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